

Neuschwanstein Castle

High on a crag in southwest Bavaria stands the fairy-tale castle of Neuschwanstein. It was built c.1869–81 for King Ludwig II (1845–86) along the lines of two ancient castles: Wartburg in Germany and Pierrefonds in France, both constructed in the medieval style with massive walls, tall towers and battlements, and palatial interiors. Eduard Riedel (1813–85) designed Neuschwanstein in a Romanesque revival style then popular in Germany, featuring round-topped arches, barrel vaults and strong walls. Built of brick faced with limestone, the main towers have overhanging battlements with machicolations and carved masonry. The image of an ideal castle is, however, idealistic: there are no real fortifications. Inside, the turreted residential block is called the Knights' House, but no knights lived there. Instead, it housed offices and service rooms. Based on Hagia Sophia in Istanbul, the throne room includes rows of arches and an apse, with pillars of imitation porphyry and lapis lazuli. Neuschwanstein was the inspiration for the castle in Disney's *The Sleeping Beauty*.

